

vertigo!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 654 March 2003 PO BOX 1628 WELLINGTON

Club nights are at Turnbull House,¹ on the first clear Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher² at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up. Meetings, run with an iron fist jam by "Al" Presidente Lowrie, start with precision at 8.00 pm with club business. Talks kick-off on the whistle at 8.01 pm.



Section night, Monday 3rd March, 8 pm at Turnbull House: "Long walks, short talks"

Back by popular demand is our short talks evening. Just in time for you to roll up and tell us what you did in the summer break & fling a few top slides about the place.

Contact Caroline (cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz) if you want a slot to present in (not to fall into, our crevasse rescue technique remains rusty).



Upcoming section night reminders

April – the Big AGM.

Come along and see community democracy in action! Vote for your fave candidates! Be your fave candidate! Pour tubs of boiling scorn from great heights on others!

The AGM is always shorter than short crust pastry, sweeter than a Chupa Chup, and as non-bureaucratic as anti-Kafka tablets...

This is your chance. Yeah. We're looking at you.

We are always looking for keen enthusiastic volunteers to be on the Wellington Section Committee.

¹ On Bowen Street, squashed behind the Treasury on Number 1 the Terrace.

² On Molesworth Street, opposite Parliament.

Nominations now open for Chairperson, Vice-Chairperson, Secretary, Treasurer, Section Representative (to attend twice yearly junkets in Christchurch – whoops, did I say that? – we mean Club Committee meetings), and common or garden Committee Members.

Feel free to nominate yourself or someone else by contacting Alan, email chairperson@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz or phone 025 653 1082 now or come along to the AGM.

If you would like to know what we get up to, have a read of the Annual Report, Financial Statements, AGM Minutes and newsletters on our web site www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz or talk to any current committee member.

If after all this you are still awake come to the meeting!

But there's more...!

...*Richard Wesley* will also do a presentation on his climbing, which we are sure will be *Primo!*



Steve Keys on the summit ice slope of Mt Aspiring about 2900m. The south face drops 1200m on the right of the ridge



Cheap climbing at Fergs

As an Alpine Club member you can now climb at Fergs Rock and Kayak for only \$5 EVERY Monday night, and at any other time for only \$8 (usually \$12). Make sure you carry your card and that your membership is up to date.



Our website

Reminder about our web site www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz. Over half of Wellington section members are now subscribed to our free email discussion group. If you would like to get or communicate information of interest then go to our web site www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz for instructions on how to join.



NZAC Governance

Your Club Committee is looking at how the NZAC is being run. If you have comments on the current set up or suggestions to improve it then please let one of your National Reps know.

Contact either Caroline (cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz) or Maria (mc@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz).



Distaghil Sar Fund Applications

This fund was set up as a memorial to Chris Hoare, Andy Boas and Steve Thornley, Wellington Section members who died on Distaghil Sar in the Karakoram in August 1996.

The fund is made up of donations from families and friends. Awards are made every year from the interest it earns. This year the total available for awards (including interest not spent last year) is in the region of \$1000. The purpose of the fund is to assist members to become better qualified to instruct on our alpine courses.

Any member of the section may apply for an award. The closing date for applications this year is 2 May. Decisions about grants are made by the fund administrators (the section's chairperson, instruction committee convener and treasurer).

Applications should be in writing, and should specify the courses or qualifications for which financial assistance is sought; the need for such assistance; and the availability of the applicant to instruct on the section's snow courses.

Appropriate courses are NZAC or FMC instructor courses; NZOIA snow assessments or pre-assessments; risk assessment and outdoor first aid courses; or any other courses or qualifications that the fund administrators approve. Awards will be used to pay for expenses actually incurred, rather than given as a lump sum.

The decision about awards will take into account the applicants' climbing skills and judgement, ability to communicate with students, commitment to safety, previous contributions to the section's instruction programmes, and availability to instruct on the section's alpine courses in future. The available funding may be given to one applicant, or split between two or more.

Applications should be sent to Distaghil Sar Fund, NZAC Wellington Section, PO Box 1628, Wellington BY 2 MAY 2003. Awards will be announced in the June newsletter.

Willie Butler – an appreciation.

MANY CLUB MEMBERS WILL ALREADY KNOW OF THE DEATH OF WILLIE BUTLER IN A CLIMBING ACCIDENT AT POHARA IN LATE JANUARY.

EVERYONE WHO CLIMBED IN GOLDEN BAY WOULD HAVE FELT THE POSITIVE INFLUENCE OF WILLIE - DIRECTLY OR INDIRECTLY - IN TERMS OF THE CLIMBS HE PUT UP, THE GREAT ACCOMMODATION, INFORMATION AND WELCOME HE PROVIDED AT "HANG DOG" CAMPING GROUND, THE SOLID CRAG AND ENVIRONMENTAL ETHICS HE PROMOTED BY QUIET EXAMPLE, AND THE GOOD RELATIONSHIPS HE MAINTAINED FOR CLIMBERS WITH DOC.

WILLIE WAS ALSO A BIT OF A CHARACTER.

A RECENT ITALIAN VISITOR TO GOLDEN BAY WAS FASCINATED BY A MYSTERIOUS "GEORGIO DI MAZOLA" WHO, ACCORDING TO THE LATEST VERSION OF THE LOCAL ROCK CLIMBING GUIDE BOOK, HAD BEEN PUTTING A SLEW OF NEW ROUTES AT POHARA. WHO WAS THIS LOCAL ITALIAN, SILVANO ASKED OF WILLIE, AND WHERE COULD HE MEET HIM?

WILLIE HAD TO CONFESS THERE WAS IN FACT NO ITALIAN RESPONSIBLE. RATHER GEORGIO DI MAZOLA WAS BUT ONE OF WILLIE'S MANY NOM-DE-CLIMBINGS. IN THIS PARTICULAR CASE WILLIE CONFESSED THAT HIS INSPIRATION FOR THE NAME WAS THE LABEL FROM AN OLIVE OIL BOTTLE! KENNETH GRAHAM'S *WIND IN THE WILLOWS* (TOAD) AND AA MILNE'S *WINNIE THE POOH* (POOH BEAR) SEEM TO HAVE BEEN OTHER INSPIRATIONS FOR HIS PSEUDONYMS.

WILLIE AND HIS CONTRIBUTIONS WILL BE SADLY MISSED BY THE MANY CLIMBERS FROM ACROSS THE WORLD WHO CAME INTO CONTACT WITH HIM.

VERTIGO EXTENDS ITS CONDOLENCES TO WILLIE'S FAMILY AND FRIENDS.



MOVED HOUSE?

Please notify the Club's National Administrator of your change of address as the labels for all newsletters and club publications are generated at the HQ office.

You can contact:

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Section news: Sharing and growing

Please send your trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz so everyone can enjoy your stories, tall or short.

Camilla bowls along to the Antarctic

I spent a month in Antarctica in late 2002 doing climate related research through Victoria University. After an initial boomerang due to bad weather our US Air Force C-141 Starlifter finally made it to McMurdo the next day after a six hour flight. The first two days were taken up by the compulsory Antarctic Field Training which involved self-arrest, crampon techniques, roping up for glacier travel, constructing an emergency shelter (I slept in a snow trench), putting up polar pyramid tents, learning about sea ice, and of course, glacier travel. I saw my first big crevasses too. Back at Scott Base we spent two more days packing, sorting and testing the field equipment

We were helped out to the Dry Valleys on 16 November. Life in the Dry Valleys is indeed dry and strict environmental guidelines concern all human impact. Everything you take out must come back to Scott Base, including all solid and liquid human waste and even residual meltwater used for cooking. Forget washing hands (or anything else) with water. Paper towels are used to clean the utensils. Sanitising gel and wet wipes do the rest for personal hygiene. Even footprints take years to disappear as the environment is hyperarid and extremely cold. We worked hard, aware at all times that the next field expedition would have to wait another year. With the luxury of 24 hours of daylight available we worked late, often eating dinner after 10 pm.

I have never seen anything as beautiful as the massive Ferrar and Taylor glaciers that drain the polar plateau. We spent our first four days in the field upon Table Mountain,

camping at 1850m, collecting geological samples, and undertaking reconnaissances into the adjacent valleys. The temperature wasn't too bad, usually around -18C, but we had lots of wind which at times dropped it to a decent -40C. I learned to appreciate the solid design of the polar pyramid tent. The design hasn't much changed from the days of Scott and Amundsen. I now understand why. It is simply superior in high winds but unfortunately not light-weight, weighing 37kgs!

We then shifted camp from Table mountain to Pearse Valley. It felt like a hot spell with only -5C during the day. We spent the next ten days digging pits, collecting samples and operating manual drill to extract ice cores. The landscape in the valley was lunar, with vast sandy glacial deposits about which were scattered ventifacts (wind-shaped rock boulders) of all sizes. Several glacial tongues flow into the valley, some hanging on the valley walls and looking like they'd slide off at any minute.

The glaciers were alive with strident metallic shrieks and cracks that kept us attentive - our camp wasn't all that far away from one of the glacier tongues! Standing in front of a wall of ice 50 m high with ears ringing in silence, then hearing the glacier crack - the sound being amplified by an amphitheatre of millions of cubic metres of ice - and realising how insignificant a human is in comparison, was one of the most profound experiences I had during the trip.

Antarctica is a continent of superlatives; nothing less will do any justice and too much is not enough to describe it. You think that your expectations are high when you first go there but you find that Antarctica is so much more than you could have ever even imagined. It blows you away, tears you apart and leaves you breathless, again and again.

Once back at Scott Base I worked mainly on our geological samples but also managed to visit Scott's and Shackleton's huts at Cape Evans and Cape Royds. It was a truly humbling experience standing there and seeing all the equipment, clothing, rusty cans of food, glass bottles with chemicals still in them, tools, books and journals from early 1900s. It was as if they had left yesterday. You can read about the expeditions from books that reproduce the experience with admirable accuracy (particularly those by Apsley Cherry-Garrard and Shackleton). But once you actually stand there and see for yourself these huts that were described in the books you gain a whole new level of respect for the achievements of the early explorers.

At Cape Royds we saw Adelie penguins. Truly entertaining, these highly skilled nest rock-thieves have a reputation of being Antarctic clowns for a good reason!

I finished my trip by undertaking the polar plunge into a fishing hole kindly provided by the resident marine biologists. The water was -1.4 C. It certainly made you appreciate warm clothing afterwards!

My experience in Antarctica is the most amazing thing that has ever happened to me. I am now plagued by regular relapses of the Antarctic blues. Antarctica creeps slowly under your skin and never lets go. All I can think about right now is how to get back there. My freedom is gone. I will never get it back.

I will finish with an excerpt from Kim Stanley Robinson's "Antarctica":

everything still and motionless; the clarity of the light unlike anything you've ever seen, like nothing on Earth, and you all alone in it...and your heart breaks because it is squeezed so hard, because the world is so spacious and pure and beautiful.

Thanks to Camilla Colebatch

A skerrick from Eric

Just after New Year I spent 7 days on the West Coast heading up the Wanganui River onto the Bracken Snow Field and down the Barron Glacier to the Whitcombe. Weather was excellent with great views of Whitcombe and Evans.

I did the trip with a couple of friends; Adrian Barr and Steve Yeoman.

Then later on in January I climbed D'Archiac with Graham Bussell via the East Ridge. The rock there is particularly loose and unstable. We headed out just before the north west hit and had an interesting crossing of the Clyde River on the way out.

Cheers from Eric Duggan

Aspiring no Hart stopper

The Christmas trip to Aspiring was a major success. Over two weeks of almost perfect weather, 12 section members got up the north west ridge of Aspiring, most also climbed Mt Bevan. Excellent trip everyone! The parties were: Lynn and Dieter Ayers Climbed Aspiring via the Therma on 29 December, descending the NW Buttress, having a bit of trouble with abseil ropes necessitating a knife job and a much shorter rope.

Steve Hart, Pete Crosland and Tony Garstang summited on New Years Day, having climbed Mt Bevan on the 31st.

Garth London, Warrick White, Steve Keys (UK), Jenny Henshaw, David Chittenden, Jo Jaguch (CHCH) summited on the 7th via the Ramp. Toby Johnson, Pete Laurenson, and Andy Sweet summited on the 8th, also climbing Mt Bevan for a warm up the day before.

On a trip slightly further south Andre Van Dusschoten and Nicky McIndoe crossed Cascade Saddle into the Dart, over to the Rees, stopped at Esquilavant Biv and climbed Mt Earnslaw. Phew!

Also for those who know him, Tom Zink climbed Mt Cook in late December via the Linda.

At a count that is four from AIC courses who climbed Aspiring and one who climbed Cook. Some good instruction and very able "students". Good job, good weather, no injuries (a couple of interesting incidents I heard rumours of).

How about a similar meet next year at Teichelman corner on the Linda?

This just in from Steve Hart.

Are you receiving me?

As a fun activity at our February Section night and barbecue, an avalanche transceiver searching contest was held. The idea was to use the sand volleyball courts at Fergs to allow people to practise using these essential safety items.

Everyone **seemed** to have a good time. It was good to see that people who had never used avalanche transceivers before managed to find the buried one in respectable time.

Caroline, who was using her Barryvox digital transceiver, did the fastest search. It only took her 45.97 seconds to find the "victim" and earned her a bottle of bourbon that had

been donated as a prize. It illustrates both consummate individual skill and how good the new types of digital transceivers are for finding a buried victim.

Everyone else used an SOS analogue transceiver. Times were: Pete 1' 00:44" : Kara 1' 07.32" : Peter Allison 1' 46.01" : Jenny 1' 44.71" : Garth 1' 51.97" : Mike 2' 09.21" : Dave 2' 15.08" : Lyn 2' 43.12" : Amy 3' 05.28" : Veena 3' 25.84" : Angela 3' 59.20"

Since they were looking for a signal from the buried "victim" in a 16m x 8m sand area that had concrete beneath it, these are pretty good times.

A couple of notes about avalanche transceivers :

- * These should be worn any time you venture on the snow away from an avalanche-controlled skifield area. ***Not wearing them is like horizontally engaging without contraception!***

- * Carry a shovel and a set of probes. Digging an avalanche victim out once you find them takes a lot longer than you'd imagine.

- * Always check your transceivers are operating as you leave. One of you should switch to receive mode. Everyone else should walk past that person, to ensure their transceiver causes a beep at the receiving unit. Make sure someone checks the person who checked everyone else.

- * A buried victim has a good chance of surviving if you find and dig them out within 30 minutes. After this time, their chances of survival drop rapidly. Don't waste time sending for help unless you have spare people. Check that your own safety is not threatened, and then start searching **at pace**.

- * Look for visible clues on the surface. Start looking for a signal from their transceiver from the point where they were last seen. Check first that everyone has switched to the receive position.

- * Learn how to use transceivers properly. Practise often.

- * Use avalanche avoidance techniques when you travel in the snow. Avoid highly loaded lee slopes. Travel on ridges. Look for signs of previous avalanche activity. Watch each other as you cross any hazardous areas. Choose a route that avoids terrain traps. And seek advice about the likely conditions.

Thanks Pete De Joux

'Ed into Peru on the Trail of the Incas?

I (aka Ed) recently spent several weeks in Peru hiking in the Cusco and Lake Titicaca regions and trekking the Inca Trail to Machu Picchu.

Recent changes to the regulation of the Inca Trail may be of interest to other NZAC members planning the trek.

Of utmost significance are the requirements that all trekkers must be accompanied by a locally licensed guide and that a maximum of 500 trekkers per day can start the four day trek.

The guide requirement has resulted in the proliferation of over 100 trekking tour companies in Cusco. Although the quality of their services varies widely, each company forms trekking groups of 4-20 trekkers and provides a similar package of services for the four day trek: transportation to and from the trailheads, obtaining trail usage permits and payment of trail and Machu Picchu entrance fees (\$50US), sleeping and dining tents, food and meal preparation, English-speaking guide, and porters to carry everything except sleeping bag/mat, clothing, personal items and water.

Virtually everyone trekking the trail these days books one of these packages.

The package costs vary between \$150 - \$250US and you get pretty much what you pay for; With the more expensive companies the guide actually does speak English, the food is much better, the tents are larger and don't leak; and, more importantly, the porters are paid a fair wage and are provided with food, tents and bedding; Also, the higher price companies participate in the annual trail cleanup sponsored by the South American Explorers (SAE) Club

To assist its members in selecting a trekking company, the SAE clubhouse in Cusco maintains extensive information on the companies; Three companies consistently receive high marks from SAE members: SAS, Wayki Trekking, and Inca Explorers.

The 500 trekkers per day restriction is understandable given the Inca Trail is only 49km long and that the campgrounds are limited in number and size. In fact, having trekked the trail off-season when the total was only 120, I think the number should be much less!

The usage restriction only creates bottlenecks during the high(i.e.,dry) season June - September, and may result in a 3-4 day delay in Cusco unless you have pre-booked with a trekking company. During the low (i.e., wet) season October - May, the trail usage is significantly reduced (e.g., 120 the day I started in January).

In February the trail is closed to prevent damage to the water-saturated surfaces.

My idea of trekking is to go solo or in the company of a close friend, so I was more than a little disappointed when I learned that I had to trek the Inca Trail "en masse". However, it is still a memorable experience – the expertly engineered stone-surface trail that has survived over 500 years, the traversing of mountain passes to 4200 meters, the passage through the Sun Gate at sunrise and descent into Machu Picchu, and the scaling of Huayna Picchu towering over the magnificent Inca ruins are "mountain highs" not to be forgotten.

Good to hear again from Ed McConnaughey

NZAC Wellington summer rock climbing course

Summer rock truly kicked off the second Saturday in February with 16 keen, eager, and talented students enrolled. 14 of them made it out to Baring Head for what turned out to be enchanting weather, dry rock, and lots of climbing.

Aches at Paynes

Scott Taylor, Silvano from the Dolomites, and the Editor spent some time recently rock climbing at Paynes Ford in Takaka. Homemade Italian gnocchi were eaten at Silvano's place in Nelson. Top food was also had at the architecturally interesting sod-roofed and compost toilet "Sans Souci" at Pohara and at the Saturday night spit roast at the

Bencarri Wildlife Park. The coffee and croissants met their normal high standard, as well as their normal morning fate, at the "Wholemeal café" in downtown Takaka.

Expatriate Wellingtonians Beth Burdett and Phil Castle provided a warm welcome when visited at the "Cardett" acres overlooking Pohara. They reported numerous climbing friends visiting from Wellington over the Christmas break, many of whom camped on their property. A complete 45 minute tour was provided of house and fantastic environs by Phil (Beth is still recovering from a skiing injury to her leg), including the caves and mini-crags on the property and in the next door scenic reserve. Get in now before he starts charging!

Oh, and some climbing was done. Every day of the eight we were there was employed extensively for climbing (some 60+ climbs were done in varying degrees of the usual poor rope resting carabiner hauling style). We were a bit wrung out by the end. Vague highlights included Phil dragging us up "Bilbo's Great Adventure" on the Rat Trap wall, a longish, fun (but very loose) steep climb on one of the new Pohara crags, and some unknown climb of an unknown grade that Scotty led on a whim below the Wall of Thugs.

For sale: alpine stuff

Down Jacket, top of the range Mountain Hardware down jacket for Himalayan, Antarctic, Canadian ice climbing or winter bouldering at Castle Hill experiences. Less than a year old, hardly worn, valued at US \$600.00. Selling for NZ\$600.00 ono..The warmest jacket on the market and a great deal. Scarpa Vega plastic climbing boots. UK 6.5. As new. \$350.00. Koflach Viva Soft plastic climbing boots. UK 6.5. Outer in excellent condition, inners a bit more worn. \$120.00.

Contact pdeavoll@hotmail.com

Flatmate wanted for climbing flat

Large double room in turn of the century Newtown house. Sunny aspect, quiet cul de sac. All mod cons including central heating to fit those winter chills. Handy to shops, bus stops, hospital if you injure yourself. Cost \$110 single \$130 for a couple plus usual expenses. Interested people please phone Scott a/h 380 0913.

And here are the club trips for 2003...

Easter 2003 18th to 27th April 2003 - Wilkin Valley Exploration,

Easter Weekend and ANZAC day = only 3 days leave for 9 days away! There are a host of peaks around the area to satisfy a range of skills. The Wilkin Valley is in Aspiring National Park. Objectives could include Castor, Pollux, Alba. Easy tramping is available. Please show your interest early, because transport booking has to be made well in advance.

Contact: Don French don.f@xtra.co.nz. phone: 06 377 7117

Queens Birthday Weekend 2003 – The Inland Kaikouras

A chance to taste early winter snow in the inland Kaikouras. Kevin Patterson is planning to get to Tapuouenuku next June. To get in quick with your place contact him at: Kevin.Patterson@nzmp.com, ph:04 566 0975.

Post Monsoon 2004 (September/October)

How about a slightly longer trip - to Nepal? Several people have indicated interest in a section climbing trip to attempt several trekking peaks, Island Peak and Lobuje East have been suggested as reasonably straightforward objectives. This could include a non-climbing trek party also. Trip leaders for both are emerging as discussions go on. To indicate an initial interest email the trip co-ordinator, trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz.

Other Sections' trips

Don't forget there are other sections of the NZAC out there. Check out there trips by going onto the main website www.nzalpine.org.nz and clicking on the individual section newsletters.

Thanks to everyone making an effort to generate club trips. Remember, trips can be any length, any level of difficulty and any size (a trip of two people is just as valid as a trip of ten – but can you take a trip by yourself? Ed.). We have a trip template and plenty of suggestions for those who want to give it a go. Do contact me even if you want ideas for private trips. Nothing will be set in stone! sh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, or phone 04-9738079



Wellington Section Directory: 2002 contact list

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